

TEETH OF LAW
A bulldozer demolishes the house of Javed Mohammad in Prayagraj on June 12

ANI

The demolition, on paper, was carried out on the grounds of building law violations, but the state government led by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath made no attempt to hide that it was an act of political retribution. The chief minister's media advisor Mritunjay Kumar tweeted a photograph of bulldozers in Kanpur on June 11 with a statement that "every Friday is followed by a Saturday". CM Yogi Adityanath also warned that there was no place in civil society for "anarchic elements". Opposition leaders and civic rights activists slammed the government for demolishing not just buildings but cocking a snook at constitutional rights and democratic principles.

In all, over 300 people have been arrested over the violent protests in UP; a preliminary list of people has been handed over by the police to the PDA to examine their properties for lapses.



"Miscreants must remember that after every Friday comes a Saturday"

– MRITYUNJAY KUMAR
Media Advisor to Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath

BULLDOZER: 'POPULAR' TOOL

Despite the criticism, the BJP seems to have found a new weapon in the bulldozer to target criminals and silence critics and rivals. As a symbol of uncompromising state power, it is popular with supporters too.

It all started with the Adityanath government demolishing the properties of fugitive gangster Vikas Dubey in July 2020. The police claimed the action was taken in search of weapons and explosives. Later, a committee led by Justice B.S. Chauhan, formed to probe the subsequent encounter killing of Dubey, accepted the police reasoning.

To free land from the illegal occupation of criminals, the Yogi government has liberally used the Uttar Pradesh Gangster and Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act, 1986—popularly known as the Gangster Act—which allows the authority concerned to attach properties of gangsters who it believes